FLAGBEARERS OF PARTICIPATIVE DEMOCRACY

Panchayati Raj goes a long way in accomplishing community participation and empowering the marginalised and vulnerable in the hinterland through grassroots administrative institutions. As we celebrated the National Panchayati Raj Day 2022, here is a close look at the trailblazing journey of Panchayati Raj Institutions in transforming rural India...

Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) play a predominant role in the delegation of power and resources to villages. The role of PRIs acquires crucial significance in the attainment of cherished ideals of good governance including Gram Swaraj and localisation of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Now, how far have the PRIs come in achieving these goals is a matter of deliberation. Before moving on to discussing further how PRIs have made democracy function at the local level and how they evolved over time, let's first have a brief idea of the Panchayati Raj system.

Mahatma Gandhi deserves special mention for conceptualising Panchayat Raj in India. He envisioned panchayats as a small self-sufficient republic that entails total participation of the people and equal opportunities for all. Going ahead with the Gandhian philosophy of Gram Swaraj, the Balwant Rai Mehta Committee in 1957 played an important role in giving a framework for the states to develop their own Panchayat System.

However, PRIs which are called the institutions of local self-government, were institutionalised in the year 1993 in India.

It's been 29 years since they came into existence through the 73rd Constitutional Amendment that paved the way for the formation of a three-tier Panchayati Raj system in the country comprising Zila Parishad at district level headed by a Zila Parishad chairperson; Panchayat Samiti at block level headed by a Panchayat Samiti chairperson, and Gram Panchayat at village level headed by a Panchayat Mukhiya or a Sarpanch, varying in states.

ROLE OF WOMEN

The 1993 amendment has proved to be a catalyst in bringing more than 14.5 lakh women into leadership roles in the country's local governance. At present as many as 20 states namely – Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Punjab, Rajasthan, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Tripura, Uttarakhand and West Bengal – have 50% seats reserved for women in their PRIs. States such as Karnataka are giving the much-needed impetus to women into governance with more than 50% women representation in PRIs. Since

